

Broadening the positionality in migration studies: *Assigned insider* category

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Abstract

This article contributes to the debates on positionality in migration studies by introducing *assigned insider* as a new category. I define it as a position when both the interviewees and the researcher are of the same local origin in which the researcher is considered ‘an insider of the host community’ and the interview questions are about a migrant group. I developed this category based on interviews with host community members during my field study in Bursa, Turkey, where I was born and raised. Previous studies focused on the researcher being an insider from a migrant community or being an outsider conducting research on a migrant community different from his/her own. Assigned insider has two elements that require it to be considered differently: same local origin operates as an overriding feature that goes beyond ethnicity and the interviewees being from the host community involves different ethical aspects than that from a migrant community. I argue that these reflect on the researcher during the interviews through active and passive discontent manifestations of the interviewees. While the former emphasises the direct confrontations of the interviewees that lead them to ‘correct’ the researcher, the latter manifests itself through non-verbal ways, which can result in refraining from answering questions.

Keywords: insider–outsider, interviews, methodology, positionality, researcher position

1. Introduction

When it became clear that my dissertation will be in Bursa, where I was born and raised, I was aware that my background would give me better access and faster rapport-building, as I was familiar with the research site and the social norms of the group that I was going to interview (Al-Makhamreh and Lewando-Hundt 2008; Chacko 2004; Labaree 2002). However, it had been years since I lived in Bursa, and I do not feel an attachment to the

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city or its people. Hence, I did not consider myself to be either an insider or an outsider (Ergun and Erdemir 2010). When I started my interviews with the host community members, who are born and/or raised in Bursa, it quickly became apparent that the interviewees saw me as 'one of them' regardless of how I saw myself. Further, with any questions that the interviewees did not approve of, I was either confronted or met with reluctance without being considered an outsider. My position was determined by the interviewees based on their expectations from me, and the extent to which I was a 'good insider' or a 'bad insider' depended on their assigned position. By expectations, I indicate the perceptions, attitudes, and behaviours of the interviewees towards the researcher based on the rapport-building, familiarity with the field site, and developed commonalities during the interviews. The observations deriving from the expectations and the outcomes that I came across during my field study motivated me to write this article.

Insider/outsider categorisation has been widely discussed in social sciences and migration studies. Previous studies on insider/outsider positionality have mostly defined it as a dichotomy. Over the years, many scholars stated that the distinction between an insider and an outsider is more of a continuum, rather than a dichotomy, or a reflection of a situational position that is negotiated between the researcher and the interviewee (Carling, Bivand Erdal and Ezzati 2014; Kusow 2003; Labaree 2002; Nowicka and Cieslik 2014; Skrutkowaski 2014). These studies acknowledged that the researcher's position can be determined not only by the researcher him/herself but also by the interviewees. This dynamic also showed that insider and outsider positionality can be a fluid situation. Focussing on migration studies, Carling, Bivand Erdal and Ezzati (2014) expanded and layered the insider/outsider categorisation by introducing 'third positions', through which the researcher might encounter various in-between positionalities during interviews with migrant communities. However, these studies did not include the situation wherein the researcher is considered as an 'insider of the host community' by interviewees when conducting research about a migrant community. Specifically addressing this gap, this article is based on my personal experiences in the field and to offer guidance to other researchers when they find themselves in similar situations.

Hence, I argue that 'insider of the host community' needs to be taken as a different category than being considered as an insider by the migrant community. Thus, I name it as *assigned insider* and define it as a position that is attributed to the researcher by the interviewees who are part of the host community in which both have the same local origin and when the topic of study is the migrant community within the same locality. This might seem like the contexts where the researcher is considered as an insider by the interviewees in migrant communities when the study is about a migrant group. However, I argue that (1) same local origin and (2) interviewing the host community members are the elements that distinguish *assigned insider* from the previous categories and contribute to the literature for researchers to pay attention.

By 'the same local origin', I indicate the local context that the researcher and the interviewees either grew up with or lived in, for a certain period of their lives, which might lead them to have overlapping lived experiences. This shared understanding can override ethnicity or nationality, uniting the individuals under a separate bond. Migration studies

are concerned with ethnicity or nationality in the insider/outsider categorisation in depth (Nowicka and Ryan 2015), such as ‘assumed insider’ (Ryan 2015). I interviewed ethnic Turks, Kurds, Bulgarian-Turks, etc. who considered themselves as members of the host community in relation to the local origin. For instance, the way I talked made it obvious that I was from the city they are inhabiting, which immediately created a friendlier atmosphere as I had a shared lived experience with them (Dwyer and Buckle 2009; Labaree 2002). While other topics came up in the initial stages of the interview, a back-and-forth dialogue, as described by De Andrade (2000), started to occur to find things in common. This commonality occurred through the local origin that we share. Therefore, what put both sides under the same roof was the city in which the fieldwork was taking place.

Secondly, having the host community members as the interviewee group expands the existing literature based on the difference in ethical concerns related to the interviewees. Most of the migrant communities, particularly forced migrants, or refugees, are considered hard-to-reach or vulnerable communities (European Commission Directorate General for Research and Innovation 2020; Fedyuk and Zentai 2018; Jacobsen and Landau 2003). Vulnerability aspect requires researchers to focus on migrants’ personal security in relation to their legal status, the precarious and demanding conditions that they might be in, their surroundings, living conditions, power relations with the host community members, deportation possibilities, etc. (Zapata-Barrero and Yalaz 2019). However, as the *assigned insider* category is about the host community members, it does not entail the same ethical concerns as migrants. This does not mean that the host community members do not have any ethical concerns, like anonymity and confidentiality in interviews (Kaiser 2012), but the ethics of interviewing host community members cannot be put into the same category as that of interviewing migrants. For instance, I believe that the reasons of not wanting to participate can be fundamentally different for a host community member and a forced migrant. Therefore, this positionality category that I introduce differs from the previous ones in migration studies.

Based on these elements within the *assigned insider*, I demonstrate that there are two reactions through which interviewees can address their expectations and disappointments during the interviews. First reaction, active discontent, reveals itself through direct confrontation by questioning the researcher’s intentions and aiming to ‘correct’ the researcher. Second reaction, passive discontent, exhibits itself through mimics, gestures, and long pauses during the interview and may result in abstentions from answering the questions. Interviews and their level of quality have long been questioned and various methods of improvement have been introduced to develop better analysis because of their potential to unravel the dynamics and negotiations throughout the research process (Fedyuk and Zentai 2018; Rathbun 2008; Silverman 2017). I argue that identifying and addressing these reactions are crucial for collecting the best possible data and strengthening the data collection process through interviews owing to its face-to-face nature (Brinkmann 2013).

The structure of this article unfolds in five parts. The second section offers a literature review on insider/outsider positionality in migration studies. The third section summarises the research topic and its empirical background. The fourth section defines and explains the assigned insider category, while the fifth section concludes.

2. Literature on insider/outsider positionality

Within positionality debates, an outsider is considered more of an impartial observer and the insider is viewed as being more likely to produce a better understanding of the study group (Kauffman 1994; Merton 1972). While outsiders may occupy a position in which they can use distance to develop more subjective analyses, it is acknowledged that being insiders provide easier access, quicker rapport-building, and easier communication between researchers and others in the field (Asselin 2003; Bonner and Tolhurst 2002; Brannick and Coghlan 2007; Chavez 2008; Yakushko et al. 2011). More recently, rather than this duality, the idea of 'in-betweenness' has been recognised.

Insider/outsider categorisation is expressed as a continuum and described as an embodiment of multiple categories, such as gender, age, class, etc., which may or may not operate simultaneously (Barker and Smith 2001; Bourke 2014; Ganga and Scott 2006; Jacobs-Huey 2002; Major and Savin-Baden 2011; Mullings 1999; Tarrant 2014). This is mostly addressed through the researcher's social position, personal traits, experiences, and beliefs (Berger 2015). This can be influenced by various factors involving the researchers' theoretical perspective or the respective power relations (Corlett and Mavin 2017; Pardee et al. 2018; Sidaway 2000). Cui (2015: 356) states that a 'researcher-researched relationship is a dynamic one and subject to negotiation'. For instance, Weiner-Levy and Queder (2012) argue that, although they thought that they were aware of their positions based on their backgrounds, before the field research and in relation to the interviewees, during their interactions, their positions were influenced, which consequently influenced data collection's process. This negotiation influences not only researched-to-researcher but also researcher-to-researched (Ryan and Golden 2006). However, as my focus concerns how the researcher is perceived by those being researched, and what challenges this may lead to, in this article, I focus on the first part of this negotiation.

Migration studies are mostly concerned with migrant communities, refugees, and other related demographic groups. The researcher in these studies is predominantly either a community member of the migrant group or a non-community member in which ethnic differences can become more of an operating element than others (Gawlewicz 2016; Leung 2015; Morosanu 2015; Nowicka and Cieslik 2014; Nowicka and Ryan 2015; Ryan 2015). While the idea of an 'ethnic lens' has been criticised in migration studies (Glick Schiller and Caglar 2009; Wimmer and Glick Schiller 2003), it may be inevitable as the basis of migration studies involves individuals that either have different ethnicity or nationality than the individuals in the destination country. Recognising the role of ethnicity and further expanding positionalities, scholars in migration studies focussed on variations in insider/outsider debates wherein two studies became salient.

Carling, Bivand Erdal and Ezzati (2014) introduced 'third positions' that a researcher might encounter during their interactions with migrant communities, while also presenting different layers within this categorisation. The authors list specific markers that influence the position of the researcher in the field while conducting interviews. These markers include name, occupation and title, gender and age group, physical appearance, clothing styles, parenthood, visible pregnancy, language skills and language used, cultural competence, sustained commitment, religion, and migration experiences. Each marker can also be used as a personal trait that influences the positionality of the researcher.

Based on these markers, the authors establish five categories. An *explicit third party* (1) refers to researchers who have no connection to either the majority or minority (migrant group) while conducting research on migrants. An *honorary insider* (2) is someone who has developed relationships through good use of language skills or by being involved with a member of the researched migrant community, which may result in the researcher gaining a position of acceptance, despite not being a member of the migrant community. An *insider by proxy* (3) category defines the position when the researcher is a migrant himself/herself while conducting research on another migrant community. Taking this category further, in the *hybrid insider-outsider* (4) category, the researcher has elements that she/he shares with the majority and the minority group, particularly when they can be an immigrant within a different community but are conducting research on a different migrant community, in which both the researcher and those being researched are the majority community's inhabiting members. Finally, being an *apparent insider* (5) involves being a researcher who is also a member of the migrant community they are researching, but without having undergone similar experiences. Each of these 'third positions' makes a crucial contribution to migration studies by delineating the differences within the various positionalities.

Broadening the debates on positionality, Pustulka, Bell and Trabka (2019) analysed the dynamics of positionality in relation to the various stages of the project faced by researchers in migration studies. They focus on the temporality of the positions that researchers attain during the research process. As the authors share ethnicity with the migrant group of interest, at the initial stage they are considered *apparent insiders*. During the fieldwork, parallel to the questions they faced during the data collection process, their status shifted towards becoming *trespassing insiders*. This part involves participants being unwilling to disclose information, leading to self-monitoring. During the analyses, researchers found themselves to be *distant insiders* as they needed to evaluate the results from a professional perspective. In the last stage of their project, the researchers framed their positions as being those of *ambassadorial insiders*, in which they were trying to be fair to the group they researched and the audience during dissemination.

To date, most of the studies that focussed on the methodological aspects of conducting interviews in migration studies paid attention on the process of interviews with migrant communities. However, migration studies involve 'a wide range of focuses, from migrants to host society and its actors, from migration-related policies to public institutions' (Zapata-Barrero and Yalaz 2018: 4). Concerning host society, many scholars studied attitudes and perceptions of the host community members in relation to migrants (Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner 2016, 2017; Hangartner et al. 2019; Hainmueller and Hiscox 2007, 2010; Valentine 2008). These studies form an important part of migration studies, through which researchers improve upon migration-related topics in theory and practice, from the host community members' perspective regarding migrant communities. Consequently, I ask what are the challenges an 'assigned insider' might face during data collection.

3. Research topic and empirical background

My study's research question focuses on the use of urban public spaces by the host community members following an influx of Syrian refugees in the Turkish city of Bursa. Bursa

is in the north-western part of Turkey and has a population of 2.936.803 million. It is the fourth largest and seventh most Syrian populated city in the country (also second most Syrian populated non-border city following Istanbul) with 164.379 registered Syrians, who constitute 5.6 per cent of Bursa's population ([Directorate General of Migration Management \(DGMM\) 2019](#)).

For an in-depth analysis, I conducted interviews with 60 host community members who were either born and/or raised in Bursa, continue to live there, or have lived there for more than 15 years. Additionally, I conducted eight elite interviews with people in positions of power at the local government, local non-governmental organisations, and locally based experts on migration. My questions to host community members involved topics on changes in the neighbourhood, the daily activities of the interviewees, their perceptions of Syrians, and their daily interactions with Syrians. I conducted preliminary fieldwork in January and June 2018, an extensive field study based on interviews and field observations in October and November 2018, and a follow-up field trip in March 2019.

In contacting my interviewees, I relied on both random and purposeful sampling, supported by snowball sampling. I started by randomly asking people with stores whether they would agree to do an interview. This allowed me to talk to people from different backgrounds (Turkish, Kurdish, etc.) and different age groups and genders and to have a diverse group of interviewees. Since I was also born and raised in the same city, rapport-building was easier during the initial stages of the dialogue despite differences in ethnicity. To introduce myself, I told them that I am a doctoral student at a Swedish university. As Sweden has either a neutral or positive connotation among the people of Turkey, it ignited positive curiosity towards the research topic. My introduction also involved where I was originally from, followed by a dialogue of commonalities.

My research period coincided with Turkey's rapid democratic backsliding. Apart from the discourses at the official level, the host community members' perceptions of Syrians have long been overlooked. Therefore, despite the increasing level of surveillance ([Tansel 2018, 2019](#); [Topak 2017](#); [Tugal 2016](#); [Yesil and Sozeri 2017](#)), I had a number of interviewees who came to me because 'they heard that I am doing a research related to Syrians and they also wanted to be interviewed'. I was expecting the political context of the country to be a challenge, as the topic was highly salient, but many interviewees expressed that they 'wanted to talk and be heard'. To maximise participation, I took handwritten notes, rather than recordings. For the same purpose, I received verbal consent from everyone I interviewed by showing my interviewees how I coded them (respondent number, date, gender, age, education level, and the neighbourhood that they reside in, for example, N44-31102018-F-65-P-SEL) to guarantee their anonymity. In this article, I also refer to the interviewees with the initial parts of their code to maintain this level of anonymity.

4. Assigned insider as a new category

I developed the category of the *assigned insider* based on the qualitative interviews that I conducted. This category is attributed by the interviewees to the researcher based on shared local origin with the host community members when the topic is about the migrant community in the same locality. Host community members indicate that they

perceive the researcher as ‘an insider of the host community’ during the interview process, based on ‘we-ness’ (Portes and Sensenbrenner 1993). This may result in the interviewees expecting certain behaviours and attitudes from the researcher. The expectations that the interviewees had assigned to the researcher included social norms and behaviours during the interviews because the researcher was ‘thought to be’ from that community. This is applicable to my case, as the interviewees had expectations regarding how I asked the questions, which words I used, and what I chose to ask them about. However, the extent to which this friendly behaviour continued, how I should have acted, and how I should have asked questions in the ways they expected depended on the individual and the extent to which I represented either the ‘good’ or the ‘bad’ insider. How a researcher is positioned by the interviewees might not be predictable (Ryan and Golden 2006); however, there are both verbal and non-verbal ways to identify these positionings.

In migration studies, the existence of expectations during interviews has always been recognised and addressed. However, by introducing this category, I argue that identifying these variations in expectations and the challenges during the interviews and subsequently addressing them is crucial in the data collection process. The challenges that the researcher is likely to face during their interviews are what I would address as (1) active discontent and (2) passive discontent. I do not argue that all research conducted between a researcher and a group of interviewees that share the same local origin within that locality will inevitably result in the *assigned insider* category. Nevertheless, considering the possibility that this might occur in data collection, and being prepared for this will assist future researchers in migration studies.

4.1 Active discontent

Active discontent involves all the verbal statements that indicate dissatisfaction regarding the questions and interactions between the researcher and those being researched, aiming to ‘correct’ the researcher without aborting the interviews. This dissatisfaction stems from the discrepancy between the researcher’s expected behaviour and the expectations of the interviewees. This manifests itself in questioning the intent of the researcher in verbal manners before, during, and after the interview.

Prior to the interview, one of the most common reactions I got occurred before starting the interview, while I was introducing myself and the topic of my research. As Syrian refugees are generally a hot topic in Turkey, one of the most overarching responses I received was about my intent. The interviewees asked about this, trying to disentangle my presence in the area, the reasons behind my research question, and my intentions to interview them. Henry (2003) has stressed the importance of the identity of the researcher and its influence on the data collection during her fieldwork when she was asked ‘Where are you really from?’. This indicates the researcher’s difficulties that are attached to representation of the self in relation to the interviewees and which posed a challenge during initial interactions. I had similar encounters. One of the interviewees (N42) asked, ‘So you are from here. But who sent you? Who are you doing this for?’. These questions were often followed by a very typical question that Turkey’s natives ask one another when they meet, ‘Where are you originally from?’.

When I stated that I was from Bursa, this marked an important point in the interviews in terms of how they approached me, which changed from questioning to welcoming. Our shared local origin created a common ground to talk in the beginning and acted as a positive reinforcement. Since this participation involves the 'we-ness' feeling in the minds of interviewees, placing 'us' under the same roof as the topic was about 'them', it is safe to argue that they had certain expectations. This implies that the interviewees' expectations were shaped in a positive way as the same local origin was the uniting point, overriding ethnicity. As I had previously mentioned, I interviewed Turkish and Kurdish host community members. Thus, the same local origin and relations with the city was the common ground in our initial dialogues, which continued until the interviewees came across a question that they did not approve of. The nature of these expectations was revealed when the interviewees did not like the questions I asked and directly confronted me. Some of them even told me directly that, because I knew the culture of the host community, 'I should have asked questions differently' (N17). Similarly, while I was asking whether the leader of a city-based non-governmental organisation (NGO) knew whether there were any factions or conflicts between Syrians, he said:

Let me stop you there. It is obvious that you prepared questions with a Western mentality. But you know how it is here [in Turkey] and how we [host community members] are, in terms of hospitality. Therefore, you should have asked these questions based on the cultural elements of Turkey.

These *active discontent* statements did not stop individuals from having an interview with me or limited their degree of trust in me as an interviewer, but did result in the interviewees trying to explain the topic in depth, to 'correct the information' I had. It is for this reason that, I would argue, I was considered as an insider throughout the whole interview process, regardless of the reactions I observed. However, the extent to which I was the 'insider' in their minds depended on the person and how they framed me as a 'good insider' or a 'bad insider'. For instance, when they thought I was a 'bad insider', they took on the role of correcting the information I had to bring me to the level of a 'good insider'. Particularly, several interviewees stated that I 'should have given greater thought to the questions' (N5, N21, N49).

The interviewees also expressed their *active discontent* in the aftermath of the interviews. This mostly occurred when I asked my last question, 'Is there anything you would like to add or state?'. One such conversation (N14) proceeded as:

Researcher: Is there anything else that you would like to state?

Interviewee: The questions you have, as if you are defending Syrians . . .

Researcher: I do not defend any side; I am asking questions to develop an in-depth understanding about what is happening here.

Interviewee: Then this should not have been the way to do it. Anyways . . .

Although I did not align myself with either party (Drury and Scott 2001), what the interviewee expected of me and how the interview turned out to be, in the interviewee's mind, reflected a difference of expectations. Some parts of *active discontent*, which occurs

before, during, and after the interviews, overlap with what Pustulka, Bell and Trabka (2019) describe as a 'trespassing insider'. In my case, although the interviewees did not question my insider position, they questioned how much of an insider I was. As these were voiced statements, they were easier to detect and address during the data collection, which researchers should pay attention to during interviews.

4.2 Passive discontent

The second element of the assigned insider category is *passive discontent*. I define this as all the non-verbal actions of the interviewees that might lead to self-monitoring in their answers. This is particularly important for migration research involving the researcher and research participants from the host community, when the topic involves the immigrant community. What emerges as an ethical challenge is to observe what the interviewees are stating 'non-verbally' regarding the immigrant community. These involve examples, such as expecting the researcher to finish the interviewee's sentences by staying silent, deferring answers, and/or making facial expressions and gestures. While this overlaps with migrants' 'self-monitoring' their answers (Pustulka, Bell and Trabka 2019) because the host community members are in a different position in the society, I state that host community members' choice to refrain from answering differs than the migrants'. For instance, migrants' reasons behind not answering questions can be linked to their legal status and fear of identification leading to deportation. As I will show next, the host community members prefer not to answer due to the discrepancy in their expectations from the researcher and how the researcher acts or asks questions. Although scepticism of the host community members can be linked to lack of trust in addition to what I argue as disappointment, the reason behind staying silent or giving evasive responses does not derive from their vulnerable position.

Passive discontent can be detected throughout an interview by following unspoken manners, which can reveal as much as the spoken part of the interview (Bengtsson and Fynbo 2018). Unlike previous studies, which have considered silence in an interview as a failure (Jacobsson and Akerström 2013), Bengtsson and Fynbo (2018: 21) argue that silence can reveal "social realities" important for their selfhoods and self-presentations', particularly in contested topics. However, in this article, I argue that it is crucial to understand whether they result from the *assigned insider* expectations of the interviewee. Reluctance to answer can be the outcome of lack of interest and/or an attitude of indifference to the question. On the contrary, within *assigned insider*, having expectations manifests itself in more surprised and/or shocked body language and/or facial expressions. To differentiate, I will demonstrate through examples from my experiences during interviews.

As detecting non-verbal manners is more difficult than detecting active discontent, I looked at two interviews and used a comparative approach to demonstrate the differences between indifferent answers and disapproving answers. In the first interview, I had involved an individual who did not pay much attention to the research and my questions. Particularly, in the questions I asked about playgrounds and use of streets, the interviewee's lack of attention became evident because his store was at the crossroads of two streets, near a playground. His answers to the use of streets and the presence of Syrians in playgrounds were short and generic without pauses, such as 'I do not know', 'I do not pay

attention', and involved random yes and no (N30). His responses involved terms, such as 'whatever', 'they say so but I do not know', and 'I do not mind whoever does what'.

Contrarily, a store owner (N36), who I also interviewed, did not hide his dislike for Syrians by answering some questions through responses, such as 'I do not know if you can write this down but they are all inglorious.' I asked him, 'What do you think about Syrians opening stores in the neighbourhood? Why?'. He paused for 10 s before saying, 'I am very uncomfortable with their presence', followed by, 'Because they support each other and discriminate against us'. Although I probed further, he repeated this with similar long pauses by making a gesture that we use in Turkish to mean 'I want to say something but I will not.' Furthermore, when I asked whether he thinks Syrians have integrated or not, and why, he answered briefly, 'Absolutely not, because their social life is different.' As opposed to the first example, in the second one, the interviewee had a different mindset that resulted in him omitting specific answers, despite encouragement. I argue that this indicates a different type of non-verbal manner than simply not answering a question, particularly, when combined with facial expressions and gestures.

Moreover, *passive discontent* also manifests itself as a form of self-monitoring. This becomes more evident when the interviewee does not question you or your aim, but instead refrains from answering in a certain way. I argue that this specific aspect of *passive discontent* is derived from the inner conflict of the interviewee during the interview. These expectations are parallel to what De Andrade (2000) calls the 'assessment of identity', which involves evaluating the level of insider you are in relation to the community that you are interviewing. For instance, when the interviewees consider you to be an insider and they have to make statements about an 'outside' group, in this case, immigrants, they expect you to know particular answers or expect you to finish their answers without explicitly stating what they want to say.

To offer a better understanding and provide further examples, I rely on my questions to the host community members regarding the presence of Syrians. I asked them about the extent to which the host community members are comfortable with having Syrians in the community, a topic that I probed by asking seven consecutive questions. When I asked 'What do you think of Syrians living in the neighbourhood also going to the parks in the neighbourhood?', the answers that they did not want Syrians to go to the parks resulted in self-censorship, followed by pauses or half sentences saying 'You know the answer ... (N14, N37)', or 'How can I be in the same place with ... You know ... (N22)'. This became more evident when I repeated the question differently, or asked them whether they could elaborate on their answer. These answers turned into active discontent resulting from expectations, as stated in the previous section. By acknowledging the difficulty in detecting *passive discontent*, in this section, I have shown the differences between indifference and deference, which could be crucial in understanding the expectations of the interviewees during data collection, with respect to being an *assigned insider*.

5. Conclusion

In this article, I introduced the *assigned insider* as a new category, regarding insider/outsider positionality in migration research by expanding the existing categories. I developed

this category based on my fieldwork experience, wherein I interviewed the host community members of the city of Bursa, where I was born and raised, about the migrant community. The issue of what happens when a researcher is considered as an 'insider of the host community members' has been overlooked in migration studies. To address this, I focussed on having the same local origin as a common ground between the researcher and the interviewees, rather than ethnicity or nationality. Moreover, because the interviewees are members of the host community, the ethical concerns that are mostly attached to migrant communities do not apply to this category of positionality. These findings enabled me to develop a new category in positionality that needs a different approach in migration studies.

Increasing the awareness of positionality to overcome the challenges that I stated in this article based on the *assigned insider* is necessary for data analysis, for two reasons. First, interviews always involve a level of perception and the background and beliefs of the researcher. However, addressing how the position of the researcher is perceived by the interviewees and whether there are any expectations will lead to a better analysis. This will be particularly important for the field studies when there is a shared local origin, while conducting research with the host community members. Secondly, as I showed, the reactions of the interviewees will have variations. Being able to address these differences and negotiating with the interviewee during the interview, without asking leading questions, will enable the researcher to come up with constructive solutions. This is particularly significant for the interpretation of the interviewees' responses.

While I introduced the category of *assigned insider*, I also acknowledge that, in this article, there are points that I fell short on demonstrating. For instance, the question of whether *assigned insiders* will be similarly experienced in other contexts or not remains to be explored. Moreover, whether there are other elements that might influence the data collection when the researcher is in the *assigned insider* positionality require further research. In addition, it would be interesting to observe whether this positionality is transferable to other qualitative methods in migration studies, like focus groups. Adopting a broader perspective in migration studies that involve the host community members as part of positionality will enable the migration scholars to conduct in-depth analyses.

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